



DIFFICULT CONVERSATIONS

How to Discuss What Matters Most

Douglas Stone, Bruce Patton and Sheila Heen



The Big “So What”

Difficult conversations are a normal, unavoidable part of our personal and professional lives. Yet, most people dread having them since such conversations—if not properly handled—can make things worse. **This book equips us with the skills and steps to handle difficult conversations in a way that fosters understanding and effective problem-solving.**



Introduction



A difficult conversation is anything you have difficulty talking about, e.g. ending a relationship, asking for a pay-raise, or addressing a hurtful behavior.



Every difficult conversation follows a certain structure. Specifically, there are 3 types of difficult conversations that present different issues and complications:

- The “What happened?” conversation;
- The Feelings conversation; and
- The Identity conversation.



Often, we enter a conversation to deliver a message, e.g. to prove a point or get others to do what we want. Issues arise because each party focuses on his/her own agenda and viewpoint. To handle difficult conversations effectively, you must:

- Shift your goal from persuasion to learning; and
- Learn how to manage the 3 types of conversations.

KEY QUOTES

“Delivering a difficult message is like throwing a hand grenade...there’s no way to throw a hand grenade with tact or to outrun the consequences...Choosing not to deliver a difficult message is like hanging on to a hand grenade once you’ve pulled the pin.”

“At heart, the problem isn’t in your actions, it’s in your thinking.”

“To make the structure of a difficult conversation visible, we need to understand not only what is said, but also what is not said.”



In this summary, we'll start by zooming in on the 3 types of difficult conversations, before explaining how to create a learning conversation.



The "What Happened?" Conversation

This conversation centers around different views about what happened (or should happen), who's right, who's to blame etc. **We each feel that our viewpoint is correct, when in reality we make wrong assumptions on 3 fronts:**



Truth: We assume that "I'm right and you're wrong" when most difficult conversations are really about conflicts in subjective values or perceptions. For example, "you're too inexperienced" or "you're driving too fast" are not facts; they're merely opinions.



Intention: We assume we know the intention behind the other party's action or non-action, when we may be totally wrong, e.g. you think your colleague is shouting to humiliate you, when he's just trying to make himself heard above the noise.



Blame: We're quick to blame others, which blocks us from examining other factors (including ourselves) that may have contributed to the situation.

Let's break down these 3 issues in detail and how to address them.



Uncovering the Truth

Don't argue about who's right. Do explore each other's stories.



Why we argue and why it's counter-productive.

- Logically, we may agree that there're 2 sides to a story. But deep inside, we each believe our story is the "right" one and the problem lies with the other person. When you assume someone is naive, you may try to "teach" him the truth. He in turn assumes that you're an arrogant know-it-all. The argument leads nowhere and the relationship is damaged.

KEY QUOTES

"Difficult conversations are almost never about getting the facts right. They are about conflicting perceptions, interpretations, and values...They are not about what is true, they are about what is important."

"We all have different stories about the world because we each take in different information and then interpret this information in our own unique ways."

- In reality, we all have different stories and perceptions about the world because:

- (i) We have *different information*: First, we filter information differently, e.g. an artist may look for different things from an analyst, an observer sees a situation differently from the person-in-charge. Second, no one can know your complex inner state (e.g. your hopes, dreams, fears, constraints) better than you do.
- (ii) We *interpret the same info differently* due to our past experiences (e.g. upbringing, traumas) and different implicit rules about how the world works (e.g. “boys mustn’t cry” and “you should squeeze the toothpaste from the bottom of the tube”).
- (iii) We’re *biased toward our self-interests*, paying more attention to data and conclusions that fit our interests and beliefs.



Shift from certainty to curiosity. Start by acknowledging that you don’t have all the facts/info. Be curious about the other person’s story as well as your own (including the assumptions underlying your story and responses). Your goal is not to decide who’s right or wrong; it’s to understand where you’re each coming from so you can jointly move forward.

- Use the “And Stance”. It doesn’t have to be either your story or theirs. Learn to embrace your story *and* theirs. For example, Jane made a mistake *and* you made things worse; you hurt Tim *and* he embarrassed you publicly. Seek to understand their story instead of simply accepting or rejecting it.
- You can be curious in any situation, even if:
 - (i) You’re factually right. For example, you may be right that smoking is bad for your son. But in an argument about why he should quit, the crux isn’t about whether smoking is good or bad. It’s about understanding each other’s stories: why he feels the need to smoke, why you’re so upset about him smoking, etc.
 - (ii) You’re sharing bad news (e.g. firing someone or ending a contract). Being curious about the other

KEY QUOTES

“Things don’t change, because each is waiting for the other to change.”

“Certainty locks us out of their story; curiosity lets us in.”

“Because you may have different information or different interpretations, both stories can make sense at the same time.”

“Remember, understanding the other person’s story doesn’t mean you have to agree with it, nor does it require you to give up your own.”

person's story doesn't mean you have to agree with it. You can be both curious *and* firm about your decision.



Clarifying Intentions

Don't assume they intended the bad outcomes. Do separate the intent of their actions from the impact.

 We make 2 common mistakes:

- We make wrong assumptions about others' intentions. First, we tend to attribute intentions based on their impact, e.g. if we feel hurt, we'll assume the other person *meant* to hurt us. Second, we assume the worst of others but the best of ourselves, e.g. if your staff forgot to submit a report, she's careless; but if you forgot the report, you're just overworked. Such assumptions hurt our relationships because:
 - (i) We assume bad outcomes are due to bad intentions, and assume bad intentions are due to bad character. For example, if assume your husband meant to hurt you because he's selfish, then you'll go on to judge *everything* he says/does based on that assumption.
 - (ii) When we accuse others, they get *defensive*.
 - (iii) In fact, our assumptions can become *self-fulfilling*, e.g. if you assume your boss doesn't trust you with responsibilities, you may get demotivated and your lackluster performance eventually leads to your boss giving you less responsibility.
- Good intentions don't negate the bad impact. When someone accuses us of bad intentions, we intuitively try to clarify (e.g. "I was only trying to help"). This backfires because:
 - (i) We miss what they're really saying. When someone says, "Why did you do this to hurt me?", he's actually saying that (a) you intended to hurt him and (b) he's hurt. When you clarify your intentions, you only address the 1st message and neglect the 2nd one.

KEY QUOTES

"Once we think we have someone figured out, we see all of their actions through that lens, and the stakes rise."

"Often we say 'You intended to hurt me' when what we really mean is 'You don't care enough about me.' This is an important distinction."

- (ii) We over-simplify our motivations. In reality, our intentions are never purely “good” or “bad” and we may not even be aware of our own complex motivations.

In short, what you intended doesn't matter as much as how the other person ended up feeling.



To avoid the 2 mistakes:

- Separate impact from intent. Recognize that your view is just a hypothesis that should be validated.
 - (i) Ask yourself 3 questions to gain clarity: (a) What did he/she actually say/do? (b) How did that impact you? and (c) What assumption did you make about his/her intentions?
 - (ii) Check your hypothesis: state specifically what the person did, how it impacted you, and explain your assumption about their intentions, making it clear you're only seeking clarity or confirmation (not stating it as a truth). It's perfectly normal for the other person to be somewhat defensive, so prepared to clarify you're only trying to uncover what happened.
- Acknowledge the other person's feelings before you address your intentions. Review your own intentions and be open to the idea that they were complex instead of 100% good.



Shifting away from the blame-game

When something bad happens, we often start blaming one another. This stops us from learning what's truly behind the problem and how to correct it. **Don't focus on blame. Do map out the contribution system.**



Focus on contribution, not blame.

- Blame is about judging if someone caused a problem in the past and if/how they should be punished. Pinning the blame on 1 person rarely solves the problem since there're always multiple contributors. For instance, an employee who takes bribes from a supplier is clearly at fault. But firing the person won't address other contributing factors

KEY QUOTES

“The more you can relieve the other person of the need to defend themselves, the easier it becomes for them to take in what you are saying.”

“Once we think we have someone figured out, we see all of their actions through that lens, and the stakes rise.”

“Talking about blame distracts us from exploring why things went wrong and how we might correct them going forward.”

like the hiring process, lack of internal checks and balances, cultural norms etc.

- Contribution is about diagnosing how various parties and factors contributed to an outcome. It helps us to uncover what really happened and how to improve the situation. For example, there're always many contributing factors when a spouse cheats. Without understanding those factors, you can't improve the relationship. Remember:
 - (i) The goal is to seek understanding, not assign blame.
 - (ii) We're often more interested to have our feelings acknowledged, i.e. to hear the other person say "I'm sorry I hurt you" rather than "It was my fault".
 - (iii) Don't blame the victim. Just because someone contributed to their own problem doesn't mean they're to blame. If you were mugged in a dark alley late at night, you'd have contributed to the situation but you aren't to blame for it.



Map out the contribution system:

- Consider 4 ways you may have contributed to a problem:
 - (i) Avoiding the problem till now
 - (ii) Being unapproachable
 - (iii) Shutting down a discussion when things get heated up
 - (iv) Imposing your implicit role assumptions on others
- Use 2 approaches to identify your own contribution:
 - (i) Role reversal: put yourself in the other person's shoes
 - (ii) Look at the situation as a neutral third party



The Feelings Conversation

Feelings are often at the heart of difficult conversations. They influence our thoughts and actions. Avoiding them will only lead to more hurt and misunderstanding.

KEY QUOTES

"Blame is about judging and contribution is about understanding."

"Understanding is the goal, not assigning percentages."

"Difficult conversations do not just involve feelings, they are at their very core about feelings."

✳ In difficult conversations, we often try to hide our feelings and stay rational, e.g. you may pretend to have a professional discussion with your boss about the new team structure when you're silently upset that he promoted your colleague over you. Bottling up your feelings will only backfire.

- Your feelings will leak out in your tone of voice or body language. Or, they may explode in destructive or embarrassing ways.
- Unexpressed feelings distract us from fully listening or expressing ourselves. They can lead to a loss of confidence in the long run.



Handling feelings in difficult conversations

Use these 3 guidelines to constructively express your feelings.



Sort out what you really feel. Our feelings come in complex bundles and we may not be aware of (or willing to face) some of them.

- Examine your emotional footprint. All of us are more comfortable with some feelings than others. The pattern may differ for different relationships. Reflect on the feelings you find hard to express, and why. Remember: it's normal to have feelings. Your feelings don't define who you are, e.g. "bad" feelings like anger or jealousy don't make you a bad person. Don't hide your feelings—they're just as important as others' and hiding them will only weaken (not protect) your relationships.
- Dissect singular feelings to uncover your full bundle of feelings. You may think you're angry at your child for lying, when you're actually also feeling disappointed, guilty, unsure and sad. By recognizing the full spectrum of feelings, you can gain insights about the situation or relationship, and express yourself fully.



Negotiate with your emotions. Your thoughts affect your feelings. When you change your perceptions, your feelings will change too.

KEY QUOTES

"Feelings are too powerful to remain peacefully bottled. They will be heard one way or another."

"It's hard to hear someone else when we are feeling unheard, even if the reason we feel unheard is that we have chosen not to share."

"By keeping your feelings out of the relationship you are keeping an important part of yourself out of the relationship."

- Re-examine your story and theirs, question your assumptions and consider the wider contribution system. This should lessen your antagonistic feelings toward the other person.
- Make it a point to acknowledge the other person's feelings, e.g. "I didn't realize you felt that way". Don't gloss over it to focus on the problem, or try to "fix" the feelings.



Share your feelings, not your assumptions about the other person.

- We often confuse our feelings (e.g. insecurity) with judgments ("you should've been there for me"), attributions ("you betrayed me"), problem-solving ("it'd have worked if you did this") and characterizations ("you're so selfish"). When you feel the urge to blame someone, it signals that there are important emotions driving you.
- Describe your emotions without being emotional. Link the feelings back to the problem. Express your full range of feelings, e.g. you're angry but also appreciative and worried. Begin with the words "I feel..." to focus on expressing your feelings without judgment, blame or attribution.



The Identity Conversation

During difficult conversations, we're constantly asking ourselves, "what does this say about me?" We seek to protect our sense of self. For example, a pay-raise discussion isn't just about the money; it's really about your self-worth and self-image.



When someone says something that raises questions about our identity, we get thrown off-balance, making it hard to think clearly or communicate effectively.

- Difficult conversations bring up 3 key identity issues: (i) Am I competent? (ii) Am I a good person? (iii) Am I worthy of love?
- We tend to adopt an "all-or-nothing" approach, e.g. you're good or bad, generous or greedy, competent or useless. This leads us to respond in 2 extreme ways:

KEY QUOTES

"The route to changing your feelings is through altering your thinking."

"Understanding feelings, talking about feelings, managing feelings—these are among the greatest challenges of being human."

"You'll be astounded how often difficult conversations are wrapped up in both people reacting to what the conversation seems to be saying about them."

- (i) We *deny* the feedback to protect our sense of self (e.g. “he’s criticizing my work because he doesn’t understand it”); or
- (ii) We *exaggerate* the feedback and change our self-image (e.g. “he’s right...I’m totally useless”).



In a difficult conversation, you’ll inevitably hear unpleasant things about yourself. It helps to anchor your identity in advance:

- Know the identity issues that matter most to you. Look for recurring patterns when you feel off-balance in difficult conversations. Do you respond most strongly when certain aspects of your identity are threatened?
- Use the “And Stance” to acknowledge your complex identity. For example, you can be loyal *and* leave your job for a better career opportunity. Accept that you *will* inevitably (i) make mistakes, (ii) have a mix of good and not-so-good intentions, and (iii) have contributed to the problem in some way.



Remember these 4 tips:

- Don’t try to control others’ responses. Even if you want to avoid upsetting the other party, you really can’t control their feelings. Trying to do so will only backfire. Use the “And stance”: enter the conversation with the goal of addressing an issue *and* expressing your feelings *and* giving them the space to feel what they feel.
- Prepare for possible responses. Imagine how the conversation may play out, what you may learn, how the other person may respond, and the possible identity issues it may trigger.
- Project into the future (say, 30 years from now). What advice would your future self give about your current situation?
- If you’re feeling overwhelmed, take a break to regain your balance. It’s ok to say “I’m really surprised by what you’ve just shared. I’d like some time to think about it.” If the issue is relevant to both sides, lay out explicitly, e.g. “I get the sense that this all boils down to whether I’m being a good boss. Is this how you feel as well?”

KEY QUOTES

“No one is always anything. We each exhibit a constellation of qualities, positive and negative.”

“Don’t measure the success of the conversation by whether or not they get upset.”



Create a Learning Conversation

Now that you understand the challenges associated with the 3 conversations, *here are the steps for preparing for and navigating a difficult conversation.*



1. Prepare by considering the 3 conversations

Take time out to walk through the 3 conversations.

What Happened?			Feelings	Identity Issues
Stories	Impact/Intent	Contribution		
My story?	My intentions?	How did I contribute?		
	Impact on me?			
His story?	His intentions?	How did he contribute?		
	Impact on him?			

 Unravel what happened by considering: (i) your respective stories and where they came from, (ii) the impact and possible intentions on both sides, (iii) how each of you (and other third parties) contributed to the problem.

 Understand your feelings: explore your emotional footprint and examine your complex spectrum/bundle of emotions.

 Anchor your identity: clarify what aspects of your identity are threatened and how you can be more grounded.



2. Know your Purpose → Decide if you should raise the issue

 Get clear on your purpose for initiating a conversation, and what you hope to achieve from it.

- You should start a conversation to gain mutual understanding. Adopt a learning stance with 3 purposes in mind:

(i) Understand their story (perceptions, feelings, constraints)

KEY QUOTES

“The paradox is that trying to change someone rarely results in change. On the other hand, engaging someone in a conversation where mutual learning is the goal often results in change.”

- (ii) Express your emotions and viewpoints
- (iii) Find ways to jointly solve the problem or move forward.

- Do not start a conversation if:

- (i) The real conflict is within you rather than between you and the other person.
- (ii) There are better ways to resolve the issue, e.g. by changing your own contribution.
- (iii) Your purpose isn't a good one. This includes (a) trying to change the other person, (b) using the conversation to vent or get emotional release, or (c) doing a hit-and-run. If you're going to talk, then plan in advance and do it properly; otherwise, don't do it at all.



Sometimes despite your best efforts, the best approach is to simply let go. Help yourself to get over it with 4 liberating assumptions:

- You're responsible for doing your best, not to make things better.
- The other person has limitations and imperfections too.
- The conflict doesn't define who you are.
- You can let go and still care for the other person.



3. Start from the Third Story



Begin with the Third Story, i.e. what a neutral third-party (e.g. a mutual friend or a marriage counselor) may observe.

- Do not start from your own story (i.e. describe the problem from your perspective) or trigger identity issues by implying things about them or their character.
- Do think like a mediator: see/describe the problem in a way that's simultaneously true for both sides.
 - (i) Your views are simply different (not better or worse). Both sides can hear each other out without giving up your own views. Even if you still disagree, you'll have

KEY QUOTES

*"If you're going to talk, talk.
Really talk...you can't do it on
the fly."*

a better mutual understanding and a higher chance of finding a viable way forward.

(ii) Describe the gap in your stories objectively without judgment, e.g. “We seem to have different views about project management. You prefer to manage the details personally while I prefer to delegate the details to other team members.”

- Even *if the other party initiates* the conversation, you can still steer it toward the Third Story.



Share your purpose and extend an invitation. Explain your aim of mutual understanding and problem solving, then invite them to partner with you to figure things out.

- You can say something like: “I sense that we each see the situation differently. I’d like to share my perspective and to learn more about yours.” Use phrases like “Can you help me to understand....” or “Let’s work out how we can...”
- Be persistent to show you have both parties’ interests at heart, but don’t force them to engage. You can even share your internal conflict, e.g. “In my own story, I assume that you’re being selfish, but that seems unfair and I’m hoping you can help me get a better perspective.”



4. Explore Their Story and Yours



Take turns to explore the 3 conversations from your respective viewpoints. Specifically:

- Explore the *source of your story* (e.g. “My reactions probably stemmed from a similar incident with my previous boss....”).
- Share the *impact* on you (e.g. “I felt really uneasy when....”).
- Take responsibility for your *contribution* (e.g. “I suspect I made things worse when I...”).
- Describe your *feelings* (e.g. “It was really hard for me to bring this up, but I felt that we should talk about it....”)

KEY QUOTES

“Changing our stance means inviting the other person into the conversation with us, to help us figure things out.”

- Examine identity issues (e.g. “I probably feel so strongly about this because I’ve always considered myself to be...”)



Listen from the inside out. When you truly listen to the other person, (i) it helps you to understand them, and (ii) once they feel heard/understood, it helps them to listen to you.

- Manage your inner voice. Be aware of the things you’re thinking but not saying (e.g. “That’s unfair”, “How dare you say this”). Acknowledge that voice, then remind yourself to stay curious since you don’t know as much as you think you do. If you can’t quieten the inner voice, then talk about it, e.g. “I really want to hear what you have to say, but I’m feeling a bit defensive at the moment and it’s affecting my ability to listen fully.”
- Use inquiry for learning. Don’t use questions (a) to make a statement (e.g. “Must you drive so fast?”) or (b) poke holes at their argument (e.g. “If you did your best, then why did Tom resolve the issue so quickly once he took over?”). Do (a) ask open-ended questions (e.g. “What did you have in mind?”), (b) ask for concrete info (e.g. “Can you share an example?”), and (c) ask questions about the 3 conversations (e.g. their assumptions, feelings, and how your actions impacted them).
- Use paraphrasing for clarity. Paraphrase what they said to ensure you’ve understood them, and to show you’ve heard them.
- Listen out for their feelings and acknowledge them. When people express their feelings, they’re really asking: “Do you understand how I feel? Do you care?” Always acknowledge feelings before you move into problem-solving.



Express yourself, clearly and powerfully. This requires that you have a clear purpose and know you’re sharing something worthwhile.

- Know that you’re entitled to express yourself but your entitlement is no more or less than the other person.
- Don’t beat around the bush or make them guess what you mean. Use the “Me-Me And” approach to get to the heart of the matter, e.g. “I think you’re really capable, and I think you’re not putting enough effort into this project.”

KEY QUOTES

“We have a deep desire to feel heard, and to know that others care enough to listen.”

“Feelings crave acknowledgment...They won’t be happy until they get it, and nothing else will do.”

“Expressing yourself well in a difficult conversation has nothing to do with how big your vocabulary is or how eloquent or quick-witted you are.”

- Separate fact from opinion. Preface your opinions with phrases like “it’s my belief that...” or “my opinion is...” Share where your views or opinions came from.
- Don’t exaggerate with words like “always” and “never”.
- Express yourself in terms that they can relate to e.g. “I have this compelling need for the house to be clean and tidy, just like how you must keep your car spotlessly clean”. Cater to their mode of absorbing info, e.g. do they relate better to visuals or numbers?
- Ask them to paraphrase back.
- Explicitly ask them if/how they see things differently.



If the other person keeps focusing on blame and who’s right, try these approaches to bring things back on-track:

- Use reframing to translate destructive statements to constructive ones. For instance, if they insist “It’s all your fault!”, you can reframe it as “I’m sure I’ve contributed to the problem. Perhaps we both have. Instead of focusing on whose fault it is, can we try to figure out how we got here, so we can work out a way forward?”
- Even if the person is being difficult, it always helps to listen first. Listen intently and ask questions to understand how he/she sees the issue. Once people feel heard, they no longer feel the need to repeat themselves and can start listening to what you have to say. It also helps you to share your views in ways they can relate to.
- If, after reframing and listening, the other party still monopolizes the conversation, attacks and interrupts you, you can name the dynamic explicitly to clear the air. You may say something like: “I’ve tried to share my views 4x times now. Each time you cut me off in mid-sentence. I’m not sure if it was intentional, but it’s really frustrating for me. I’d like to hear your perspective and I’d also like to finish what I’m saying.”

KEY QUOTES

“Communicate your feelings in a way that invites and encourages the recipient to consider new ways of behaving, rather than suggesting they’re a schmuck and...there’s nothing they can do about it.”

“You can’t move the conversation in a more positive direction until the other person feels heard and understood.”



5. Take the Lead in Problem-Solving



Now that you have a mutual understanding, you're ready to move into problem solving. You can find a mutually-acceptable solution even if you don't fully agree with each other.



Opposing views often come from a clash of assumptions. If you can identify those assumptions (e.g. "The kids won't be safe alone at home"), you can propose to test your hypotheses.

- Explain the parts of their story that don't make sense to you (instead of presenting the gap using your own story).
- Share how you can be persuaded, and ask if there's anything that can persuade them.
- Ask for their advice.



Be prepared to brainstorm creative solutions and invent options. Rather than squabble over whose approach to take, consider if there're certain standards/principles you can apply.



If you still can't reach agreement, decide if it's better to accept less than what you want, or accept the consequences of a disagreement.

KEY QUOTES

"For many people, realizing that they don't have to agree brings a sense of great liberation, relief, and empowerment."